Fünetik Alfübet: "Keep It Simple" Phonetic Alphabet

Version: 0.9 (Draft for Community Review)
Author: Wesley Wright
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1. Abstract

The Fünetik Alfübet is a simplified phonetic writing system for English designed to maximize clarity and learnability for beginning and intermediate ESL learners. Rather than adopting the complexity of the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA), this system follows a strict One Sound, One Character approach, using primarily modified Latin letters with minimal diacritics. The design is grounded in Canadian English pronunciation and prioritizes pedagogical transparency over exhaustive phonological analysis. Key features include a streamlined vowel inventory based on familiar long-vowel notation, the intentional omission of schwa, and a simple representation of rhotic vowels using ʊr or vowel+r sequences. Diphthongs are avoided entirely, reflecting natural articulatory glides in connected speech. This draft is released under CC BY 4.0 to invite community review and iterative improvement. The document includes the full proposed alphabet, design rationale, a reference chart, and a sample text transcribed using the system.

2. Objective

This document presents Version 0.9 of the Fünetik Alfübet, a simplified phonetic alphabet for English. It follows a strict 'One Sound, One Character' design principle to support ESL learners and improve pronunciation transparency.

3. Design Guidelines

- Use one grapheme per phoneme whenever possible.
- Minimize the use of non-Latin letters.
- Keep accents/diacritics minimal.
- Respect IPA conventions where reasonable.
- Break rules only if it simplifies learning.

4. Background

This system was created from a practical teaching perspective rooted in Canadian English pronunciation. Its purpose is to offer a clearer alternative to IPA for beginners, focusing on intuitive sound–symbol mapping.

5. Dialect Notes

This was written based on Canadian English (Southwestern/Southern Ontario) pronunciation. Other dialects might include sounds not captured here. If so, feel free to adapt/add as necessary (if you do, it would be helpful to the reader/student to specify what dialect/regional pronunciation is being used).

6. Rationale for Vowels and Rhotic Forms

The vowel system is based on familiar long-vowel markings (ā, ē, ī, etc.). Schwa is omitted intentionally because in Canadian English it reduces toward u, ʊ, or i depending on context. Rhotic vowels are rendered using ʊr or vowel+r sequences such as wōrm, mirroring natural articulatory transitions.

7. Discussion of Diphthongs

Diphthongs are avoided because they introduce complexity without aiding pronunciation. Learners naturally glide between vowels during speech. This system therefore uses monophthong symbols even where IPA traditionally marks diphthongs.

8. Fünetik Alfübet Reference Chart

NOTE: All examples below reflect Canadian English (Southwestern/Southern Ontario). Other dialects may map certain vowels differently (e.g., cot–caught merger,[1] /oʊ/ variation).

Fünetik Alfübet	IPA	Optional Variant(s)	English Examples
vowels			
a	æ		m**a**d, h**a**m
ā	eɪ	A	r**a**te, r**ay**, r**ai**n, gr**ey**, gr**ea**t, r**ei**n, r**eig**n, w**eigh**t
e	ɛ		y**e**t, h**ea**d
ē	i	E	sh**ee**p, cit**y**, l**ea**f, bel**ie**f, c**eil**ing
i	ɪ		s**i**n, w**o**m**e**n
ī	aɪ	I	b**i**te, m**igh**t, cr**y**
o	ɑ		**o**n, w**a**sp, c**o**t
ō	oʊ	O	g**o**, kn**ow**, d**ough**, t**oe**
u	ə (at times) , ʌ		**u**p, t**ou**gh

[1] In Canadian English, “cot” and “caught” are frequently merged to /ɑ/

ū	uː		t**oo**, t**o**, t**wo**, y**ou**, thr**ough**, shr**ew**d
ʊ	ə (at times) , ʊ	ù ů	p**u**t, s**oo**t, winn**e**r, t**o** (reduced), p**e**rhaps
ò	ɑː		f**a**ther, **awe**, d**aw**n, c**augh**t
ŏ	ɔː		**a**ll, **aw**ful
consonants			
b	b		**b**at, ra**bb**it
č	tʃ	¢ ₵	**ch**air, rea**ch**, fe**tch**
d	d		**d**oll, o**dd**
f	f		**f**og, **ph**oto, o**ff**, cou**gh**
g	g		**g**et, be**gg**ar
h	h		**h**it, **h**arm
j	dʒ		**j**am, **g**em, e**dge**
k	k		**c**arrot, **k**arma, **q**ueen, uni**que**
l	l		**l**ure, ba**ll**
m	m		**m**arry, wo**m**an
n	n		**n**ame, pea**n**ut
ŋ	ŋ		ra**ng**, si**ng**i**ng**
p	p		**p**ole, ha**pp**y
r	r		**r**am, me**rr**y
s	s		**s**alt, **c**ity, pa**ss**, spa**ce**
š	ʃ	$	**sh**eep, **s**ure, emo**ti**on
t	t		**t**alk, **tw**o, fa**tt**y
θ	θ	₮	**th**row, tee**th**
ð	ð	Ŧ	**th**at, bro**th**er
v	v		**v**owel, o**f**, gi**ve**
w	w		**w**edding, q**u**een
y	j		**y**ellow, **e**ulogy
z	z		**z**ebra, bu**zz**, a**s**
ž	ʒ		trea**s**ure, sei**z**ure, bei**ge**, vi**si**on

9. Sample Text: The North Wind and the Sun (Standard English Text)

The North Wind and the Sun were disputing which of them was the stronger, when a traveler came along wrapped in a warm cloak.

They agreed that the one who first succeeded in making the traveler take off his cloak should be considered stronger than the other.

Then the North Wind blew as hard as he could, but the harder he blew, the more closely the traveler folded his cloak around him; and at last the North Wind gave up the attempt.

Then the Sun shone out warmly, and immediately the traveler took off his cloak.

And so the North Wind was obliged to confess that the Sun was the stronger.

10. Sample Text: The North Wind and the Sun (Fünetik Alfübet Transcription)

```
ðu nōrθ wind end ðʊ sun wʊr dispyūtēŋ wič ov ðem wuz ðu štroŋgʊr, wen ʊ
čravʊlʊr kām ʊloŋ rapt in u wōrm klōk.

ðā ugrēd ðat ðʊ wun hū fʊrst suksēdid in mākēŋ ðu čravʊlʊr tāk of hiz klōk
šʊd bē kunsidʊrd štroŋgʊr ðen ðē uðʊr.

ðen ðʊ nōrθ wind blū az hòrd az hē kʊd, but ðu hòrdʊr hē blū, ðu mōʊr clōslē
ðʊ čravʊlʊr fōldid hiz klōk uraūnd him; end at last ðu nōrθ wind gāv up ðē
atemt.

ðen ðʊ sun shon aūt wōrmlē, end imēdēutlē ðu čravʊlʊr tʊk of hiz klōk.

end sō ðu nōrθ wind wuz ʊblījd tū kunfes ðat ðʊ sun wuz ðu štroŋgʊr.
```

11. Questions for Community Feedback

- Is the one-sound, one-character mapping appropriate across dialects?
- Are any symbols confusing or counterproductive? (The objective is to strive the balance between ease of readability/learnability while using characters that are as ASCII- / keyboard-friendly as possible)
- Which vowel distinctions need refinement?
- Should diphthongs remain represented by two characters? If so, please provide a compelling case for this.
- Though it is for a vowel (and the others are for consonants), could confusion arise between the diacritic in/pronunciation of ŏ and that for č š ž?
- Do reviewers agree that schwa can be omitted by recovering the underlying vowel (u, ʊ, or i) in Canadian English?
- Are additional diacritics necessary?

12. Recommended Citation

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13. Keywords

phonetics; phonology; ESL; English pronunciation; orthography; phonetic alphabet; applied linguistics; English language learning; simplified phonetic system; Canadian English; vowel system; rhotic vowels; second-language acquisition; phonetic transcription

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